MONTHLY UPDATE

Ethiopia: monthly update, September – October 2026

Edition of 2026-10-16-2 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

Developments reported in sources published between the beginning of last month and today, grouped by story, oldest first.

STATUS · PROGRESS · INSTITUTION HOSTING

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ICT INFRASTRUCTURE
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INCLUSION
Access to services

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India activities

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

NATIONAL FINANCIAL INCLUSION STRATEGY III (2026-2030)

- **High Digital Transaction Costs, Fraud Gaps Threaten Ethiopia's Financial Inclusion Targets: Report** — The Reporter, 3 October 2026

  An assessment of Ethiopia's second financial inclusion strategy found adult account ownership at 66 per cent in 2025 against a 70 per cent target, with some banks charging up to 11 per cent for transfers to mobile wallets. Only 29.56 per cent of 157.6 million mobile money accounts were active in June 2026; a third strategy, for 2026 to 2030, was launched alongside it.

Legislation and regulation

NATIONAL DATA MANAGEMENT PROCLAMATION (DRAFT)

- **Council of Ministers Refers Key Bills to HPR on Governance, Data, Power and Defense** — Ethiopian News Agency (ENA), 28 September 2026

  The state news agency's account of the same Council session names the bill the National Data Governance Draft Proclamation, referred to parliament with the Council's unanimous backing.

- **Ethiopia's Council of Ministers Advances New Legal Frameworks for State Institutions, Data Sovereignty, Defence and Economy** — Fana Media Corporation S.C., 28 September 2026

Ethiopia's Council of Ministers unanimously sent a draft national data proclamation to parliament, framed around data security and sovereignty, data sharing and interoperability across government, and support for AI research.

Regional collaboration

HORIZON FIBER TERRESTRIAL CORRIDOR

- **Projet de fibre optique « Horizon » : Une nouvelle autoroute numérique pour la Corne de l'Afrique** — La Nation, 9 September 2026 DJIBOUTI SUDAN

  Djibouti Telecom, Ethio telecom and Sudatel presented their Horizon terrestrial fibre project to Google, Meta, Microsoft, Amazon and other carriers and vendors in Addis Ababa on 7 September 2026. The multi-terabit link would connect cable landing stations in Djibouti and Port Sudan through Ethiopia, reducing reliance on Red Sea submarine cables. No cost or launch date is given.

Standards

CENTRAL BANK DIRECTIVE ON MICROFINANCE DIGITAL READINESS (MFI/33/2022)

- **When Digital Ambition Becomes a Tripping Stone** — Capital (Ethiopia), 6 September 2026

  In an opinion piece, microfinance practitioner Surafel Teshome argues that some Ethiopian microfinance institutions are buying mobile wallets and agent channels before they have the strategy, systems and governance to run them. He points to the National Bank of Ethiopia's Directive MFI/33/2022, which requires an IT strategy, board oversight, risk assessment, disaster recovery and IT audit.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

COMMUNICATIONS DISRUPTION IN TIGRAY

- **Tigray Cut Off Again as Communications Blackout Deepens Civilian Misery** — WardheerNews, 26 September 2026

  Internet and phone services were severely disrupted across Ethiopia's Tigray region as fighting resumed between Tigrayan forces and the federal army, reported on 26 September 2026. Ethio Telecom services were fully down and Safaricom partly working, and NetBlocks confirmed the disruption. Residents already short of cash lost access to mobile money. Responsibility for the shutdown is disputed.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

NEXT HORIZON: DIGITAL & BEYOND 2028 STRATEGY

- **Ethio Telecom Announces Successful Completion of First Year of Next Horizon Strategy** — Ethiopian News Agency (ENA), 3 September 2026

  Ethio Telecom's chief executive, Frehiwot Tamiru, said on 3 September 2026 that the first year of its three-year Next Horizon strategy left about 90 million customers and close to 61 million telebirr users. Second-year targets include 96.2 million customers and 4G population coverage of 95%, up from 82.23%.

- **Ethio telecom Next Horizon - Digital & Beyond Strategy 2028 Year II 2019 EFY (2026/27) Annual Business Plan** — Ethio telecom, 3 September 2026

  Ethio telecom published the Year II business plan of its Next Horizon 2028 strategy on 3 September 2026, targeting ETB 295 billion in revenue for 2026/27, ETB 77.45 billion of it from digital businesses. It plans 96.2 million customers, 67.69 million telebirr users, 4G on 11,014 sites, 5G in 73 towns and 268 AI servers.

- **Ethio Telecom to Expand 4G Network to 11,014 Sites in 2026/27** — Tech Africa News, 9 September 2026

  Ethio Telecom is to expand its 4G network from 6,924 to 11,014 sites in 2026/27 under the Year II plan of its Next Horizon strategy. It is a published target, not an outturn.

ETHIO TELECOM NETWORK

- **Ethio Telecom Targets 96.2 Million Customers, ETB 295 Billion Revenue in 2026/27** — TechAfrica News, 4 September 2026

  Ethio Telecom set 2026/27 targets of 96.2 million customers and ETB 295 billion revenue in its annual business plan, the second year of its Next Horizon strategy. The plan raises 4G capacity from 22.79 million to 35.31 million subscribers and 4G population coverage from 82.23% to 95%, 5G sites from 340 to 648 and 5G towns from 33 to 73, backbone fibre from 23,442 km to 25,642 km and gateway capacity from 4.3 Tbps to 5.2 Tbps, with telebirr targeted at 67.69 million customers.

SAFARICOM ETHIOPIA SECOND NETWORK

- **Safaricom Ethiopia Surpasses 15 Million Subscribers After Four Years of Operations** — TechAfrica News, 4 September 2026

  Safaricom Ethiopia passed 15 million 90-day active subscribers in under four years of commercial operation, marking five years since its unified licence of 9 July 2021. It has deployed more than 3,500 network sites, all 4G-enabled and 5G-ready, reaching about 60% of the population, and says the growing base is moving the business towards breakeven; it puts community investment at ETB 684 million over four years.

- **Safaricom Ethiopia Engages Government on Network Expansion and Digital Transformation** — Tech Africa News, 9 September 2026

  Safaricom Ethiopia put itself at 15 million 90-day active customers and more than 3,600 sites in five years of operation, at a meeting with the innovation and technology minister. Its chief executive raised infrastructure and supply-chain constraints on further rollout, including the timely customs clearance of telecommunications equipment and fibre cable.

- **Safaricom Ethiopia passes 15 million subscribers five years after getting its licence** — Tech-ish, 14 September 2026

  Safaricom Ethiopia announced on 3 September 2026 that it has passed 15 million 90-day active subscribers, five years after receiving its licence in July 2021. It had 14.7 million on 30 June 2026. The company reports more than 3,500 network sites covering about 60% of the population; no exact subscriber figure was given.

Energy

BITDEER OROMIA BITCOIN-MINING SITE

- **Ethiopia Sacrifices Lucrative Bitcoin Mining Revenue as Hydropower Crisis Deepens** — Norvanreports, 15 September 2026

  The state power utility cut supply to bitcoin mining and data-mining operations as a hydropower shortfall deepened, giving up the revenue that load was earning.

Cybersecurity

FINANCIAL SECTOR CYBERSECURITY FORUM

- **Ethiopia establishes financial sector cybersecurity forum to improve digital resilience** — Tech Review Africa, 30 September 2026

> Ethiopia set up a Financial Sector Cybersecurity Forum on 29 September, chaired jointly by the cyber agency INSA and the National Bank, for threat sharing and coordinated incident response across financial institutions.

DPI

Data Exchange

AFRICA ACCELERATOR FOR DIGITAL PUBLIC INFRASTRUCTURE (AA4DPI)

- **CDPI on its session at the Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure, 2–3 September 2026** — Centre for Digital Public Infrastructure (CDPI), 3 September 2026 MALAWI RWANDA SIERRA LEONE ZAMBIA

  The Centre for Digital Public Infrastructure led a session at the Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure, hosted by UNDP and the Centre for Open Societal Systems on 2 and 3 September 2026. Delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia covered DPI blueprints, verifiable credentials, consented data sharing and reusable open-source code.

- **Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure (AA4DPI)** — United Nations Development Programme, 8 September 2026 AFRICA

  UNDP has published the standing description of its Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure, led jointly by the Regional Bureau for Africa and the Digital and AI Hub, which supports countries to assess digital readiness, strengthen governance, build implementation capacity and develop investment-ready programmes across digital identity, digital payments and data exchange. Its first published cohort session ran on 2 and 3 September with delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia; no budget, duration or deliverable set is published for the accelerator itself.

- **UNDP's AA4DPI Programme Deepens South-South Cooperation on Digital Public Infrastructure** — United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), 8 September 2026 MALAWI RWANDA SIERRA LEONE ZAMBIA AFRICA

  Delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia, with African Union representatives, concluded a two-week South-South learning mission to India on digital public infrastructure. Convened under UNDP's newly launched Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure, it took delegates through New Delhi, Pune and Bengaluru to examine India's digital identity, payment and data exchange systems.

Digital Identity and CRVS

FAYDA NATIONAL DIGITAL IDENTITY

- **Ethiopia Announces Document Requirements for Foreign Nationals Applying for Fayda Digital ID** — Ethio Affairs, 4 September 2026

  Ethiopia has set out the documents foreign nationals must show to register for the Fayda digital ID: a passport with an Ethiopian Origin ID, residence or work permit, or investment licence, a refugee ID for refugees, and a foreign ministry ID for diplomats and international organisation staff. The requirements' issue date is not stated.

- **Fayda — 33 Proof of Acceptable Documents** — National ID Program (NIDP), Ethiopia, 7 September 2026

  The national identity programme's own page lists the 33 documents accepted as proof of identity for registration, from the local administration card and passport to birth, education, marriage and business records. The page carries no publication date of its own.

- **Ethiopia launches developer sandbox to support Fayda digital ID innovation, integration** — Biometric Update, 9 October 2026

  Ethiopia opened a public sandbox where developers and startups can test the Fayda digital identity's authentication interfaces before going live. Fayda counted more than 52 million registrations, 150 integrated partners and 208 million electronic verifications.

FAYDAVERSE DIGITAL PUBLIC INFRASTRUCTURE ENTERPRISE

- **Banks Baulk at a Bill from Public ID That Turns Commercial** — Addis Fortune, 3 October 2026

  FaydaVerse, the new state enterprise running Ethiopia's Fayda digital ID, has begun charging banks for identity checks they once got free: 10 to 20 birr per KYC record retrieval and 20 to 40 birr per biometric authentication, by volume. Its contract bars banks from passing the cost to customers and bills failed attempts; the Ethiopian Bankers Association has asked for a joint consultation with the central bank.

Digital Payments and Fintech

M-PESA ETHIOPIA CARDLESS ATM WITHDRAWALS

- **M-PESA Ethiopia Expands Cardless ATM Withdrawals Through Awash Bank Partnership** — Tech Africa News, 8 September 2026

  M-PESA Ethiopia has extended cardless ATM withdrawals to Awash Bank's machines, letting wallet holders draw cash without a bank card by authorising the withdrawal in the app. The service has been live with Bank of Abyssinia since August; the date it started with Awash Bank is not stated.

MOBILE MONEY WALLETS OPENED AGAINST ADULTS HOLDING AN ACCOUNT

- **Mobile Money in Ethiopia - A Diagnostic Report** — DFS Ethiopia Hub (Team Shega), 9 September 2026

  A diagnostic report by Ethiopia's Team Shega, published on 9 September 2026, finds that more than 135 million mobile wallets have been opened, yet fewer than one adult in ten holds a mobile money account and 0.4% rely on one alone. Drawing on Global Findex 2025, UNCDF and central bank data, it finds most inclusion gains were bank-led and makes eight recommendations.

- **High Digital Transaction Costs, Fraud Gaps Threaten Ethiopia's Financial Inclusion Targets: Report** — The Reporter, 3 October 2026

  Summarised under Strategies, plans and policies.

ETHIOPAY NATIONAL INSTANT PAYMENT SYSTEM

- **EthSwitch takes Ethiopia's digital payments push to global fintech stage** — TechReviewAfrica, 10 September 2026

  Ethiopia's national payment switch EthSwitch presented its interoperable payments work at the Global Fintech Fest in Mumbai on 8–11 September 2026, where its chief portfolio officer Abeneazer Lakew joined a digital public infrastructure panel. EthSwitch said in May that its EthioPay instant-payment service handled over one million transactions worth 5.1 billion birr in a single day.

MANDATORY FAYDA INTEGRATION WITH BANK ACCOUNTS

- **CBE Gives Customers Until November 9 to Link Bank Accounts with Fayda ID** — Birr Metrics, 16 September 2026

The Commercial Bank of Ethiopia has given customers outside Addis Ababa, Dire Dawa, Harari and 24 other cities until 9 November 2026 to link their accounts to the Fayda national digital ID, under a National Bank of Ethiopia directive. Unlinked accounts in areas already covered face debit restrictions blocking withdrawals and transfers. Linking can be done at branches or online.

PAN-AFRICAN PAYMENT AND SETTLEMENT SYSTEM MEMBERSHIP

- **Ethiopia Joins PAPSS in Major Step Towards Pan-African Payments** — FSX Business, 30 September 2026

  Ethiopia has joined the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System as its 31st member country, having signed its bylaws about a month earlier after delays over concern that financial data would be exposed to other members. Four Ethiopian banks await no-objection letters from the National Bank of Ethiopia, and PAPSS aims to connect half the country's banks by March 2027.

- **Mobile money wallets set to link with PAPSS, opening access to African markets** — Capital Newspaper, 4 October 2026

  Ethiopia's non-bank mobile-money operators and payment-service providers are preparing to connect to the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System. Each needs a letter of no objection from the National Bank of Ethiopia first, and operators are weighing a direct connection against routing through EthSwitch or partner banks.

UNIFIED GOVERNMENT PAYMENT PLATFORM

- **EthSwitch Unveils Unified Government Payment Platform** — Tech Africa News, 1 October 2026

  Ethiopia's national payment switch presented a unified government payment platform at the Ethiopia Finance Forum. It would give government bill payments one interoperable route across mobile apps, ATMs, USSD, branches and agents.

VALUE OF DIGITAL FINANCIAL TRANSACTIONS

- **Digital Finance Surge Marks Turning Point for Ethiopian Banking Sector: NBE** — Ethiopian News Agency, 1 October 2026

  Ethiopia recorded digital financial transactions worth 33 trillion birr in the 2025/26 fiscal year, Gemechis Dugasa, regulation and licensing director at the National Bank of Ethiopia, told the Ethiopia Finance Forum on 30 September 2026. He linked the growth to mobile money and digital banking and called for stronger cybersecurity, data protection and governance.

- **High Digital Transaction Costs, Fraud Gaps Threaten Ethiopia's Financial Inclusion Targets: Report** — The Reporter, 3 October 2026

  Summarised under Strategies, plans and policies.

VISA AND ETTA CONTACTLESS ACCEPTANCE DEVICE ROLLOUT

- **Ethiopia's commerce goes contactless with new Visa and ETTA infrastructure agreement** — Capital Newspaper (Ethiopia), 7 October 2026

  ETTA Solutions and Visa signed a framework agreement to roll out 148,000 contactless payment devices to Ethiopian merchants, jointly financed by both companies. The devices connect to ETTA's ZooryaPay platform, licensed by the National Bank of Ethiopia, and are certified by the tax authority as cash registers and e-receipt terminals. Merchant transaction data feed credit profiles built by Optasia. No sum is stated.

INTERNATIONAL PAYMENT CARD ISSUANCE BY DOMESTIC BANKS

- **Banks Race to Launch International Payment Cards as Forex Reforms Open New Market** — Birr Metrics, 9 October 2026

  Ethiopia's Awash Bank, with Mastercard, and Oromia Bank, with Visa, launched eight internationally accepted payment cards between them on 8 October 2026. The launches follow the National Bank of Ethiopia's February 2026 rule change allowing banks to issue such cards to foreign-currency account holders. Awash said it processed over US$60 million in card foreign exchange last fiscal year.

Sectoral management information systems

INTEGRATED TAX ADMINISTRATION SYSTEM (ITAS)

- **Re-advertisement: Request for Expressions of Interest - Selection of Technical Lead/Chief Architect for the Integrated Tax Administration System (ITAS)** — Ministry of Revenue (Ethiopia), via Get Chereta, 8 October 2026

  Ethiopia's Ministry of Revenue re-advertised on 8 October 2026 for an individual consultant to serve as Technical Lead and Chief Architect for its Integrated Tax Administration System, funded by the World Bank's Governance Modernization project (Credit 7619 ET). The role covers system architecture, vendor oversight and integration with the ministry's data warehouse and e-invoicing systems. Expressions of interest are due on 29 October 2026.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

COMMODITY EXCHANGE DIGITAL SERVICE PORTAL

- **ECX Launches Digital Portal to Cut Red Tape for Traders** — Capital (Ethiopia), 6 September 2026

  The Ethiopia Commodity Exchange launched a digital portal, built by its own IT staff, so traders no longer have to visit its offices to open accounts, renew licences or obtain reference prices and market data. Each request gets a tracking PIN and a 30-minute service commitment. An official launch is due within a month.

STATE LOGISTICS SELF-SERVICE PLATFORMS

- **Digital logistics overhaul aims to boost regional trade competitiveness** — Capital Newspaper, 13 September 2026

  Ethiopian Shipping and Logistics launched a web and mobile self-service platform on 4 September 2026 for shipment orders, cargo tracking, freight payment and documents. The Ethio-Djibouti Railway has introduced its own customer portal for booking, tracking and payment.

Inclusion

Access to services

OPERATOR FOUNDATION MEMORANDUM ON DISABILITY INCLUSION

- **Safaricom Ethiopia Foundation and FEAPD Sign Three-Year Pact to Advance Disability Inclusion** — Tech Africa News, 1 September 2026

  Safaricom Ethiopia Foundation and the Federation of Ethiopian Associations of Persons with Disabilities signed a three-year memorandum of understanding, reported on 1 September 2026, covering digital inclusion, accessible technology, education, economic empowerment, healthcare and disability-rights advocacy. No funding amount is given.

SMARTPHONE AFFORDABILITY FINANCING

- **Ethio Telecom Secures 15bln Birr Siinqee Bank Deal To Fund Smartphone Access Drive** — Birr Metrics, 3 September 2026

  Ethio Telecom secured a 15 billion birr financing agreement with Siinqee Bank, with 4 billion birr earmarked to help low-income customers buy smartphones. The state operator puts smartphone penetration at about 36% and aims to distribute 2.6 million devices in the next fiscal year. The article does not say when the agreement was signed.

WOMEN TRADERS PROGRAMME ON THE DJIBOUTI CORRIDOR

- **From export readiness to market access: EU-backed support strengthens women's participation in trade along the Djibouti-Ethiopia Corridor** — Horn Economic Review, 3 September 2026 DJIBOUTI

  Forty Ethiopian women traders and exporters attended an export-readiness workshop in Bishoftu on 30-31 July 2026 under the €32 million Djibouti Corridor programme, financed by the EU through Global Gateway, delegated to the Agence Française de Développement and run by TradeMark Africa. The programme also funds digital trade systems such as electronic phytosanitary certification.

REFUGEE WOMEN'S SIM REGISTRATION AND MOBILE USE

- **Closing the digital divide for refugee women means understanding their full experience of connectivity** — GSMA Mobile for Humanitarian Innovation (Zainab Moallin), 10 September 2026 UGANDA TANZANIA MAURITANIA GLOBAL

  The GSMA published research on 10 September 2026 on refugee women's mobile use, drawing on fieldwork with Venezuelan refugees in Colombia and in Mauritania's Mbera camp. It reports that refugee women in Ethiopia are twice as likely to have SIMs registered in someone else's name, that in Uganda about a quarter use the internet against half of men, and that in Tanzania identity rules push women to register SIMs through intermediaries.

Geopolitics

India activities

INDIA DIGITAL PUBLIC INFRASTRUCTURE LEARNING MISSION

- **Karnataka Hosts African Union, Five African Nations For Digital Public Infrastructure Exposure Visit** — The Bengaluru Live, 1 September 2026 MALAWI RWANDA SIERRA LEONE ZAMBIA

  The Indian state of Karnataka hosted officials from the African Union, Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia on 1 September 2026, on a UNDP-supported visit to study digital public infrastructure. State officials and the Centre for e-Governance briefed the delegation on digitising public services and interoperability between government systems.

- **African Delegations Explore India's Digital Public Infrastructure During UNDP Learning Mission** — Youth Village Zambia, 2 September 2026 ZAMBIA MALAWI RWANDA SIERRA LEONE

  The UN Development Programme in India hosted delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia on a learning mission on digital public infrastructure in New Delhi, Pune and Bangalore in early September 2026. The visits covered Aadhaar digital identity, the Unified Payments Interface and DigiLocker, with meetings at India's identity authority, its national payments corporation and the health and agriculture ministries.

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